

the lines between a phone and a phablet of this type are already blurring with the latest smartphones already touting displays as big as 4.85 inches.

Another approach is something we have seen in the Asus Padfone. The oddly named device, whose launch video is amongst our favourites, has a slot at the back of a processor-less tablet, where you can dock the phone. The processor in the phone powers this skeletal tablet which only has a battery inside it to charge the phone when it is docked. The added advantage with Padfone is that you can also attach a keyboard dock to convert it into a notebook. Phablet+Laptop. Phabtop, anyone?

Tabtops

Merging the laptop and the tablet is a much more sensible scenario because the major difference between the two is often the pain point for many tablet users: a physical keyboard. ASUS's Transformer series of tablets comes with its own line of docks which convert them into a laptop. While it is excellent for battery life, it adds very little value otherwise. Android really can't act as a laptop replacement as it does not support the productivity apps that make a Windows PC indispensable. But this will change with the release of Windows 8. The tablet/laptop hybrid will make even more sense with the new touch oriented version of the popular OS.

Augmented Reality tablets

We are now venturing into distinct concept device territory, but with a device that is as likely to happen as all the combinations we have speculated above.

One of the changes that has been evident in the last decade in computing is how services have evolved and become more and more people centric. The social aspect invades every technology as more and more services revolve around us, our friends and our surroundings.

It is with this at the back of our mind that we visualise this tablet of the future, where the solid slate could be



ASUS's PadFone